

Steven Richards

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Cybersecurity and AI operations leader with 20+ years of experience spanning enterprise security architecture, agentic AI systems, and full-stack systems engineering. Brings deep presales engineering expertise — Palo Alto Networks, Cylance, Optiv — alongside direct experience building agentic AI systems with LLM routing, context and memory management, RAG pipelines, prompt engineering, and AI infrastructure. Known for translating complex security and AI challenges into production-grade, scalable solutions.

AI & AUTONOMOUS SYSTEMS EXPERIENCE

Stealth AI Startup (Rook Dynamics) — Founder & Principal Engineer

2024 – Present

- **AI Operations Platform (Rust):** Multi-tenant agentic orchestration platform with secrets management, CI/CD pipelines, and HashiCorp Vault integration across 21+ engineering phases.
- **Multi-Agent AI Infrastructure:** Five-agent system using Anthropic-native MCP tooling with dynamic tool discovery.
- **AI Security & Applied ML:** Isolated AI red team training enclave with vector DB integration, OWASP targets, and adversarial testing tooling.
- **Persistent Agent Daemon (Rust):** Multi-agent coordination daemon with PostgreSQL/pgvector for RAG and Python/SQLite context management for long-running agent state.
- **Browser Extension (TypeScript/WXT):** Automated text routing, IOC lookup, and indicator defanging with LLM integration.
- **Infrastructure & DevOps:** Full ESXi to Proxmox migration. Multi-node private lab orchestrated via MCP-based remote execution.

Task Force 70 — Technology Strategist

Ongoing · Nonprofit

- Architected full platform rebuild — Next.js 14, Vercel, Railway, Stripe, Clerk — with 16 locked Architecture Decision Records.
- Maintained and enhanced production Rails application for course registration with automated workflows and staging deployment.
- Deployed and managed custom Moodle LMS for law enforcement officer training delivery.

ENTERPRISE CYBERSECURITY EXPERIENCE

Palo Alto Networks — Cincinnati, OH

Domain Consultant - Cortex (Pre-sales) | 2019 – Present

FY23: 145% · FY22: 187% · FY21: 117% · FY20: 212% · FY19: 123% — Century Club 2019–2023*

- Lead design and technical sale of advanced security solutions across Financial Services, Healthcare, Government, Education, Manufacturing, and Critical Infrastructure.
- Developed custom Insider Risk Management solution with Cortex XSOAR, replacing a failed Exabeam implementation for the region's largest financial customer.
- Applied practical AI/ML knowledge to position AI-SPM, XSIAM, and Cortex analytics; advised on AI security posture and governance.

Cylance Inc. — Cincinnati, OH

Security Engineer (Pre-sales) | 2015 – 2019

FY18: 127% · FY17: 223% · FY16: 167%

- Early adopter of AI/ML-driven endpoint security — technical lead for product evaluations using machine learning models for predictive threat prevention.

- Developed dynamic live-malware demonstration methods; delivered technical expertise enabling expansion across 5 states.

Optiv (formerly Accuvant) — Cincinnati, OH

Senior Solutions Engineer (Pre-sales) | 2009 – 2015

FY14: President's Club · FY13: #1 Account Team + President's Club · FY12: President's Club

- Delivered enterprise pre-sales engineering across a full cybersecurity product portfolio.
- Led RFP responses, executive-level presentations, and technical architecture sessions.

TECHNICAL PROFICIENCY

AI Engineering & Operations: Agentic AI, MCP, Claude Code, Anthropic SDK, RAG, Prompt Engineering, AI-SPM, LangGraph, OpenRouter, Prompt Injection Defense, Context Window Management, Agent Memory Architecture, LLM Routing, Multi-Agent Coordination

AI Project Stack: Rust (Axum, Tokio), TypeScript, React, Next.js, WXT, PostgreSQL, SQLite, Qdrant, pgvector, Ollama, Podman

Languages & Scripting: Python, Ruby / Rails, SQL, REST APIs

Infrastructure & DevOps: HashiCorp Vault, Docker, CI/CD, Proxmox / ESXi, Active Directory, DNS / DHCP, MySQL / MariaDB, Oracle DB, Infrastructure-as-Code, Git

Security Domains: NGFW, EDR / XDR / EPP, SIEM / XSIAM, SOAR / XSOAR, Zero Trust, CSPM / ASPM, Threat Intelligence, AI Red Teaming, Pen Testing, UEBA / ITDR

Platforms: Rocky Linux, RedHat, CentOS, Ubuntu, FreeBSD, OpenBSD, UnixWare, SCO Unix, Windows Server 2019+, Windows 10/11

MILITARY EXPERIENCE

United States Air Force Reserve — 906th Tactical Fighter Group

F-16 Weapons Systems Specialist (462x0) | 1989 – 1995

- Maintained and serviced F-16 aircraft weapon systems ensuring operational readiness.
- Held Secret clearance (expired).

REFERENCES

I've served as CISO of several large organizations. Wherever I go, I view Steve Richards as a trusted advisor and consider him a part of our team. His view of what is happening in the industry is both deep and broad and his focus on problem-solving is truly unique.

— Marc Yoder, Former CISO of Texas.gov and Texas Department of Transportation